

W3 Causal Systems

WHAT THIS FRAME MEANS

This frame asks you to explain why something happens — not just what happens. You trace a chain: one thing leads to another, which leads to another. The key is the mechanism — the specific reason why one event causes the next. Strong speakers name the mechanism, not just the outcome.

WHAT TO TRY

- Start with a cause and name the specific mechanism that connects it to an effect
- Extend the chain at least one step further
- Identify a system effect — what happens when multiple causes combine or reinforce each other

SENTENCE STARTERS

- "This happens because..."
- "X leads to Y, which in turn leads to..."
- "The mechanism here is..."
- "When A and B combine, the result is..."
- "This creates a self-reinforcing cycle because..."

EXAMPLE IN ACTION

"A sugar tax reduces consumption not by making sugar illegal, but by raising the price, which makes consumers reconsider purchases. Lower consumption leads to reduced demand, which puts pressure on manufacturers to reformulate products. Over time, this shifts the food supply — not just individual behavior. The mechanism is economic incentive, not direct prohibition."